

The Morning Briefing

POLITICS · LAW · MIDDLE EAST · ROME · THE WORLD

LEAD STORY — JUDICIARY

Trump administration asks Supreme Court to clear way for mail-in voting restrictions; states must respond by August 3

US POLITICS

Senate confirms Clayton as DNI, turns to SEED Act sanctions vehicle

The Senate confirmed Jay Clayton to be Director of National Intelligence on a vote scheduled for 6:30 p.m. Monday, then moved to a cloture vote on the motion to proceed to H.R. 5334, the SEED Act, the vehicle carrying a new sanctions package. No hearings were scheduled in the House.

WHY IT MATTERS

The SEED Act is the main sanctions instrument Congress has in play amid the ongoing Iran standoff, and Clayton's confirmation hands the administration a fresh DNI as that standoff continues.

Lawfare — lawfaremedia.org/article/lawfare-no-bull--confirmation-hearing-for-director-of-national-intelligence-nominee-jay-clayton

Capitol honors the late Senator Lindsey Graham

A ceremony commemorating the life and legacy of the late Senator Lindsey O. Graham (R-SC) was held in the Rotunda of the U.S. Capitol Monday morning, with a funeral service at the Washington National Cathedral in the afternoon.

WHY IT MATTERS

Graham was a central voice on Iran policy and judicial nominations; his absence reshapes both debates heading into the fall.

Jeffries, Trump take dueling economic messages on the road

House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries appeared in Pennsylvania for an affordability-focused campaign event, while President Trump appeared Monday at a General Motors facility in Michigan touting his tariff policy.

WHY IT MATTERS

Both parties are staking their 2026 midterm message on pocketbook economics.

Congress.gov — congress.gov/on-senate-floor-today

Lawfare: election speech offered no new fraud evidence

A Lawfare review of President Trump's recent primetime address on the 2020 election found it produced no new evidence for stolen-election claims.

ANALYTICAL READ

This matters directly for the mail-in voting fight now before the Supreme Court — the administration's legal theory rests on claims of vulnerability in mail voting that its own public case has not substantiated.

Lawfare — lawfaremedia.org/article/everything-trump-s-election-speech-did-not-prove

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Trump v. California: administration seeks emergency stay on mail-in voting order

The Trump administration on Monday asked the Supreme Court to stay a federal injunction and allow it to fully implement President Trump's March 31 executive order, "Ensuring Citizenship Verification and Integrity in Federal Elections." The order would direct the U.S. Postal Service to withhold mail-in ballots from voters not listed on new Department of Homeland Security-compiled "state citizenship lists." Solicitor General D. John Sauer called the lower court's order "extraordinary" and argued it "flouts settled" doctrines governing when courts may weigh in.

U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani of the District of Massachusetts had, on June 25, blocked implementation of the mail-in ballot and citizenship-list provisions for the Nov. 3, 2026 elections in the 23 states and the District of

Columbia that sued, led by California. A divided panel of the U.S. Court of Appeals for the 1st Circuit refused Saturday to let the government intervene, warning that if the order "were to take effect for the elections taking place" this fall, "it would sow confusion and threaten disenfranchisement of many eligible voters."

The Supreme Court has ordered the states to file a response by 4 p.m. EDT on Monday, August 3.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the marquee election-law case of the term, testing how far the executive can go in conditioning ballot access on new citizenship-verification infrastructure just months before a federal election.

SCOTUSblog (Amy Howe) — scotusblog.com/2026/07/trump-administration-asks-supreme-court-to-clear-the-way-for-new-mail-in-voting-restrictions

Appeals court: Trump cannot implement mail-in voting order

A U.S. federal appeals court has ruled that President Trump cannot implement his mail-in voting order — the same underlying 1st Circuit dispute now before the Supreme Court on the emergency docket, described above.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/american-politics/article-903625

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Israeli cabinet approves international force for Gaza, reconstruction pilot in Rafah

Israel's security cabinet approved letting an International Stabilization Force (ISF) enter Gaza, with the U.S.-backed "Board of Peace," directed by Nickolay Mladenov, beginning a reconstruction pilot phase in Rafah that involves building temporary housing structures for Gaza residents.

ANALYTICAL READ

This hands day-to-day Gaza administration to an internationally branded body while Israel retains the security veto over who and what enters — a structure that lets Jerusalem claim disengagement from governance while keeping operational control. Who benefits: Netanyahu's government avoids the political cost of open-ended occupation while the U.S. absorbs reconstruction-financing exposure.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/israel-news/defense-news/article-903662

West Bank violence "rapidly snowballing," officials say; Abbas calls it systemic

The West Bank security situation is, per Israeli military officials themselves, "rapidly snowballing," with forces being reinforced after an attack by Israeli settlers on the village of Tell near Nablus. PA President Mahmoud Abbas called it "systemic" settler violence and asked the UN and Arab leaders for support. A Jerusalem Post editorial separately called for Israel to confront settler violence with the same resolve it applies to Palestinian terrorism.

ANALYTICAL READ

When a paper as pro-Israel as the Jerusalem Post runs an editorial demanding equal resolve against settler violence, that is itself evidence the problem has outgrown routine denial. Watch whether Israeli security officials continue to describe this only in the passive voice.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/israel-news/defense-news/article-903755 and [article-903749](https://jpost.com/israel-news/defense-news/article-903749)

Trump denies munitions shortage behind Iran strike pause

President Trump denied that a shortage of munitions was the reason U.S. strikes on Iran paused, saying, "We have far more munitions than anyone in the world." Separately, the Pentagon listed four U.S. troops killed during the Iran ceasefire period as casualties distinct from the earlier "Epic Fury" operation, and an Iranian source told Saudi media that Tehran will hold its fire only "as long as" the U.S. pause holds.

ANALYTICAL READ

A public denial of a munitions shortage is itself notable — it responds directly to reporting alleging exactly that, and the casualty bookkeeping split suggests the administration is managing the ceasefire's political optics as much as the military reality. Iran's stated conditionality signals this is a pause, not a settlement.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/international/article-903748

Zelensky: Russia feeding Iran satellite surveillance

Ukrainian President Zelensky said Russia is giving Iran satellite surveillance data, alleging a correlation between that intelligence and subsequent Iranian strikes on Gulf states.

ANALYTICAL READ

This claim comes from Kyiv, which has its own interest in tying Russia to the Iran-Gulf confrontation to draw Western attention and resources back toward the Russia file — worth weighing against independent verification, which is not yet public.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/middle-east/iran-news/article-903665

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo XIV renews appeal for Middle East peace

Pope Leo XIV, speaking from Castel Gandolfo, renewed his appeal for peace in the Middle East.

WHY IT MATTERS

This continues a consistent line from the Pope this summer — distinct from the U.S.-Israel framing, the Holy See has repeatedly emphasized Gaza's humanitarian toll and called for a negotiated settlement rather than military resolution.

Crux — cruxnow.com/vatican/2026/07/pope-renews-appeals-for-mideast-peace

Analysis: Vatican "still hasn't learned" on abuse allegations, as Rupnik case drags on

A Crux News Analysis by Charles Collins argues the Vatican "still hasn't learned how to deal with abuse allegations," citing the ongoing case of Fr. Marko Rupnik, the disgraced former Jesuit artist whose mosaics remain inside the Redemptoris Mater chapel of the Apostolic Palace even as his canonical case continues. The Vatican has separately denied rumors that Rupnik was acquitted.

WHY IT MATTERS

Rupnik is the highest-profile clerical abuse case of Pope Leo's young pontificate, and the fact that his artwork still adorns a chapel used by the Pope himself has become a flashpoint for critics of Vatican transparency.

Crux — cruxnow.com/news-analysis/2026/07/so-far-2026-has-shown-the-vatican-still-hasnt-learned-how-to-face-abuse-allegations

Nun detained by ICE walking to Mass speaks out; bishops respond

Sister Leticia "Letty" Ugboaja spoke publicly for the first time about being detained by ICE while walking to Mass in McAllen, Texas. The U.S. bishops separately reiterated that immigration enforcement "must respect human life."

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the clearest instance yet of the Trump administration's immigration-enforcement posture colliding directly with Catholic religious practice on U.S. soil, and it has drawn a formal statement from the bishops' conference.

Crux / AP — cruxnow.com/church-in-the-usa/2026/07/nun-speaks-out-for-first-time-about-being-detained-by-ice-while-walking-to-mass-in-texas

Medjugorje shrine desecrated, damaged by fire

Bosnian authorities are investigating a desecration and fire that damaged the Virgin Mary shrine at Medjugorje.

WHY IT MATTERS

Medjugorje is one of the most-visited Marian pilgrimage sites in the world, though the Church has not dogmatically ruled on the reported apparitions; an attack on it draws international Catholic attention regardless of its uncertain canonical status.

Crux / AP — cruxnow.com/church-in-europe/2026/07/bosnian-authorities-investigate-desecration-and-fire-damage-at-medjugorje-virgin-mary-shrine

WORLD NEWS

Vatican envoy continues Ukraine mission, visits Kyiv bomb sites

Archbishop Paul Richard Gallagher, the Holy See's Secretary for Relations with States, has continued a mission through Ukraine, visiting bombed sites in Kyiv and the Maidan memorial and calling for "the conditions for a just peace."

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the Vatican's most sustained diplomatic engagement on the Ukraine war, running in parallel to, and distinct from, U.S. and European channels.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/vatican-city/news/2026-07/archbishop-gallagher-ukraine-papal-envoy-maidan-meetings.html

RESEARCH & LONG READS

US politics: what the election speech did not prove

Lawfare's Anna Bower, Julia Curlee, Renee DiResta and colleagues assess President Trump's recent primetime address on the 2020 election, concluding that after years of searching, the White House "still hasn't found" evidentiary support for its stolen-election claims. Useful background for evaluating the legal theory underlying the mail-in voting case now before the Supreme Court.

Lawfare — lawfaremedia.org/article/everything-trump-s-election-speech-did-not-prove

Foreign policy: the short-war illusion, from Iran to Taiwan

Lawfare's Julia Curlee argues the U.S.-Iran conflict shows "the U.S. won every battle but lost the war" against Iran's nuclear and proxy infrastructure — and that Beijing is drawing lessons from it about the limits of decapitation strikes and high-tech weapons for any future move on Taiwan. Directly relevant to today's Iran-ceasefire coverage above.

Lawfare — lawfaremedia.org/article/the-short-war-illusion--what-iran-teaches-beijing-about-taiwan